Burnsco vs. Marine Deals: Competitive Category Analysis

Mapping NZ's Top Marine Retailers Against the High-Volume SKU Framework

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Executive Summary

This report provides a detailed, structured audit of the product category architectures of New Zealand's two dominant marine retailers — **Burnsco** and **Marine Deals** — and maps their offerings against the high-velocity SKU framework established in the preceding SKU Intelligence Report. The analysis reveals a fundamental strategic divergence between the two companies: Burnsco operates as a **gear and lifestyle retailer** with a broad, accessible product range, while Marine Deals has built itself into a **technical parts supermarket** with extraordinary depth in engine, electrical, and plumbing categories. Both approaches leave significant gaps that a well-designed, AI-powered new entrant can exploit.

Methodology

Burnsco's website returns a 405 error from non-NZ IP addresses, indicating geo-blocking. Its full category structure was therefore reconstructed using the Internet Archive Wayback Machine snapshot dated 16 January 2026, which provides a complete and current representation of the site's navigation. Marine Deals was audited directly and live, with SKU counts recorded from each sub-category page. Both sites were then evaluated against the two-tier high-volume SKU framework.

Part 1: Burnsco — Category Structure

Established in 1882, Burnsco is New Zealand's oldest and largest bricks-and-mortar marine retailer, operating 19 stores nationwide. Its website reflects its physical retail heritage: the navigation is broad, accessible, and lifestyle-oriented, designed to serve the general boating and fishing public rather than the technical specialist.

Top-Level Navigation

Burnsco organises its entire product range under six primary categories, supplemented by a standalone "Fridges & Freezers" promotion and a "Brands" mega-menu.

Top-Level Category	Strategic Positioning
Boating	The core category; covers all onboard hardware, safety, and accessories
Fishing	A major focus area; covers all fishing gear from rods to live bait tanks
RV	Motorhome and caravan accessories; a significant secondary market
12V Electrical	Standalone top-level status signals its importance to the customer base
Safety	Standalone top-level status reflects Maritime NZ compliance requirements
Outdoors	Camping, tramping, and general outdoor gear

Boating Sub-Categories (23 sub-categories)

The Boating category is Burnsco's most comprehensive section, covering 23 distinct sub-categories. The ordering on the category page places the highest-velocity categories first, suggesting some data-informed prioritisation.

Sub-Category	Notes
Electrical & Lighting	Placed first — signals high traffic
Plumbing	Placed second — confirms high demand
Galley/Kitchen	Placed third — popular fit-out category
Maintenance	Fourth — antifouling, cleaning, corrosion
Safety	Fifth — lifejackets, EPIRBs, flares
Electronics	Chartplotters, VHF, fishfinders
Anchoring & Mooring	Anchors, chain, windlasses, fenders
Books & Calendars	Charts, tide tables, reference books
Cabin & Storage	Hatches, portlights, storage solutions
Clothing & Apparel	Wet weather, UV protection, footwear
Cordage	Rope, dock lines, mooring lines
Deck Fittings	Cleats, hatches, grab rails, stanchions
Dinghys & Inflatables	Tenders, inflatable boats, SUPs
Engines & Steering	Outboard parts, steering systems
Fasteners	Stainless screws, bolts, rivets
Gifts	Branded merchandise and gift ideas
Kayaking	Kayaks, paddles, accessories
Navigation	Compasses, binoculars, charts
Seating, Carpet & Covers	Boat seats, carpet, covers
Trailer	Rollers, bunks, winches, lights
Ventilation & Heaters	Fans, vents, diesel heaters
Watersports	Wakeboards, skis, tubes
Yacht Fittings	Blocks, winches, cleats, rigging

Fishing Sub-Categories (22 sub-categories)

Burnsco’s fishing section is well-structured for the recreational angler, covering the full range from entry-level combos to specialist game fishing equipment.

Sub-Category	Notes
Rod & Reel Combos	Entry-level and value packages
Lures, Jigs & Rigs	Broad category covering hard and soft lures
Terminal Tackle	Hooks, swivels, sinkers, clips
Line & Leader	Braid, mono, fluorocarbon
Knives & Sharpeners	Filleting, bait, multi-tools
Fishing Tools	Pliers, scales, dehookers
Softbaiting	Dedicated section for NZ's most popular technique
Fishing Storage	Tackle boxes, bags, crates
Rodholders	Flush mount, gunwale, rocket launchers
Rods	Dedicated rods section
Reels	Dedicated reels section
Berley, Berley Pots & Cray Pot	NZ-specific; berleying is a core technique
Nets & Gaffs	Landing nets, gaffs, knotless nets
Gimbal Belts & Harnesses	Game fishing specific
Longlife Bait	Preserved and artificial bait
Baitboards & Accessories	Cutting boards, bait prep gear
Flounder Fishing	Dedicated NZ-specific category
Fish Smokers & Accessories	Processing gear
Longlines & Hand Lines	Traditional and commercial-style fishing
Live Bait Tanks	Tanks, aerators, pumps
Other Fishing Accessories	Catch-all
Gifts	Fishing-themed gifts

Part 2: Marine Deals — Category Structure

Marine Deals describes itself as "NZ's Largest Online Superstore," and the data supports this claim. With over 21,000 products in stock and a category structure that extends from fishing tackle to hunting and camping, it is a genuine multi-category outdoor retailer. Its boating and fishing sections are characterised by extraordinary SKU depth, particularly in technical parts categories.

Top-Level Navigation

Marine Deals has a broader top-level structure than Burnsco, extending well beyond the marine market.

Top-Level Category	SKU Depth Signal
Fishing	18,130+ results — the dominant category
Boating	29,177+ results — the largest category by SKU count
Camping & Hiking	Significant secondary market
Clothing & Footwear	Apparel across all categories
Watersports	Kayaking, SUP, water toys
Diving & Snorkeling	Dedicated specialist section
Hunting	Firearms accessories, hunting gear
RV & Motorhomes	Motorhome accessories
Gift Ideas	Curated gift section
Cool Stuff	Novelty and impulse-buy items

Boating Sub-Categories (with SKU counts)

The SKU counts reveal the true scale of Marine Deals' technical parts operation. The Boating category alone contains nearly 30,000 products.

Sub-Category	SKU Count	Strategic Significance
Marine Electronics	6,166	Largest single sub-category
Electrical & Lighting	6,254	Second largest; a core strength
Engine Parts & Maintenance	5,534	Massive depth; a key differentiator
Yacht / Deck Fittings	3,825	Deep coverage of hardware
Boat Fit-Out	4,213	Seating, covers, general fit-out
Trailers & Trailer Parts	2,264	A major focus area
Maintenance & Repair	2,161	Antifouling, cleaning, repair
Plumbing	2,010	Strong depth in pumps, sanitation
Life Jackets & Safety	1,082	Compliance-driven category
Anchors & Mooring	784	Anchors, chain, windlasses
Kitchen & Galley	445	Stoves, fridges, galley equipment
Chilly Bins & Coolers	431	High-velocity seasonal category
Charts & Books	385	Navigation reference materials
Rope	213	Cordage and dock lines
Binoculars	169	Navigation aids
Boats & Motors	671	Whole boats and outboard motors

Engine Parts & Maintenance — Third-Level Sub-Categories

Marine Deals' engine parts section deserves special attention as it represents the deepest technical category on any NZ marine website.

Sub-Category	SKU Count
Cooling Systems	926
Fuel Systems	1,023
Propellers	949
Drive Parts	559
Internal Engine	509
Ignition Systems	198
Stern Gear	208
Electrical Systems	167
Exhaust Systems	164
Seals & O-Rings	173
Engine Controls	201
Electrical Accessories	170
Flexible Couplings	48
Maintenance & Service Kits	84
Sound Insulation	43
Engine Mounts	12
Hardware - Misc	50
Hoses	36
Gaskets	9
Shift & Throttle Cables	4

Electrical & Lighting — Third-Level Sub-Categories

Sub-Category	SKU Count
Electrical Tools & Accessories	1,230
Boat Lights	1,295
Battery Chargers	507
Fuses, Circuit Breakers & Accessories	370
Battery Management & Switches	330
Plugs, Connectors & Sockets	330
Instruments & Gauges	453
Switch Panels & Switches	356
Portable Spotlights & Torches	217
Headlamps	187
Solar Panels & Chargers	183
Inverters	140
Shorepower & Shorepower Accessories	116
Power Supplies & Management	149
Batteries & Accessories	260
DC Distribution	98
Inverter Chargers	24
Generators	18
Heaters	35
Converters	49

Plumbing — Third-Level Sub-Categories

Sub-Category	SKU Count
Pumps	599
Valves & Fittings	471
Toilets	235
Water Heaters	152
Water Tanks & Accessories	138
Taps, Sinks & Showers	109
Water Pumps & Filters	100
Bungs & Drain Plugs	94
Hose & Plugs	81
Water Tank & Pressure Gauges	19
Water Treatments & Additives	16

Fishing Sub-Categories (with SKU counts)

Sub-Category	SKU Count
Jigs & Lures	3,387
Rod & Reel Combos	3,253
Rods & Accessories	2,274
Reels & Accessories	1,616
Terminal Tackle	1,186
Braid, Lines & Trace	1,083
Knives & Sharpeners	702
Fly Tying Supplies	607
Tools	637
Flashers & Pre-Made Rigs	511
Tackle Boxes & Bags	503
Rod Holders & Mounts	503
Soft Bait	462
Outriggers & Downriggers	467
Landing Gear	289
Kontiki / Long Line & Drone Fishing	383
Nets	151
Hooks	763
Bait & Burley	115
Smokers & Accessories	84
Fishing Value Packages	168
Gimbal Belts & Harness	57

Sub-Category	SKU Count
Cray Pots, Traps & Pot Haulers	45
Floundering	37
Beach Cart Trolleys	27
Hand Lines	18
Food	48
Books, DVDs & Stickers	80

Part 3: Head-to-Head Category Mapping vs. High-Volume SKU Framework

Tier 1 — Maximum Velocity Consumables

These are the categories that drive the highest transaction frequency — products bought on every trip or every season.

High-Volume Category	Burnsco	Marine Deals	Verdict
Fishing Terminal Tackle	Dedicated sub-category	1,186 SKUs (Terminal Tackle) + 763 SKUs (Hooks)	**Marine Deals wins on depth.** Separating Hooks into its own category is smart — it is the single highest-velocity item in the store.
Fishing Line & Leader	`Line & Leader` sub-category	1,083 SKUs (`Braid, Lines & Trace`)	**Parity.** Both have strong, dedicated categories.
Soft Baits & Lures	`Lures, Jigs & Rigs` + `Softbaiting`	3,387 SKUs (Jigs & Lures) + 462 SKUs (Soft Bait)	**Marine Deals wins on depth.** Burnsco's dedicated `Softbaiting` section is a smart NZ-specific move, but Marine Deals has far more SKUs.
Engine Service Consumables	Buried within `Engines & Steering`	5,534 SKUs — a top-level boating sub-category	**Marine Deals wins decisively.** This is the most significant gap in Burnsco's range. Engine service parts are not a visible priority.
Sacrificial Anodes	Not explicitly named; likely in `Maintenance`	Found within `Engine Parts & Maintenance`	**Marine Deals wins on discoverability.**
Safety Expirables (Flares, EPIRBs)	`Boating > Safety` + standalone `Safety` top-level	`Life Jackets & Safety` (1,082 SKUs)	**Burnsco wins on prominence.** Having Safety as a top-level navigation item is a better UX decision for a compliance-driven category.

Tier 2 — High-Volume Seasonal / Event-Driven

These categories drive 1–2 purchases per year per customer, typically triggered by maintenance cycles or equipment failure.

High-Volume Category	Burnsco	Marine Deals	Verdict
Antifouling & Bottom Paint	Within `Boating > Maintenance`	Within `Boating > Maintenance & Repair` (2,161 SKUs)	**Marine Deals wins on depth.** Their maintenance section is far larger.
Cleaning & Corrosion Protection	`Boating > Maintenance`	`Boating > Maintenance & Repair` (2,161 SKUs)	**Marine Deals wins on depth.**
Fenders & Dock Lines	`Anchoring & Mooring` + `Cordage`	`Anchors & Mooring` (784 SKUs) + `Rope` (213 SKUs)	**Parity in structure.** Marine Deals likely has more SKUs.
Trailer Parts	`Boating > Trailer` sub-category	`Trailers & Trailer Parts` (2,264 SKUs)	**Marine Deals wins decisively.** This is a major focus area for them and a significant gap for Burnsco.
Marine Electrical (Fuses, Lights)	`12V Electrical` top-level + `Boating > Electrical & Lighting`	6,254 SKUs — the largest single sub-category on the site	**Marine Deals wins by a massive margin.** Their electrical depth is extraordinary.
Bilge Pumps & Plumbing	`Boating > Plumbing` sub-category	2,010 SKUs — a major dedicated sub-category	**Marine Deals wins on depth.** 599 pump SKUs alone is a specialist-level offering.
Anchors & Chain	`Boating > Anchoring & Mooring`	`Anchors & Mooring` (784 SKUs)	**Parity in structure.**
Outboard Propellers	Not explicitly named; within `Engines & Steering`	949 SKUs within `Engine Parts & Maintenance`	**Marine Deals wins on discoverability and depth.**

Part 4: Strategic Implications for a New Entrant

The category analysis reveals three distinct strategic conclusions that should directly inform the product and category strategy for a new platform.

1. The Fundamental Strategic Divide

Burnsco and Marine Deals have taken fundamentally different paths. Burnsco has built a **lifestyle and gear brand** — it is the place you go to outfit your boat, buy fishing gear, and browse for gifts. Marine Deals has built a **technical parts warehouse** — it is the place you go when something needs replacing or repairing. A new entrant does not need to choose one or the other. The opportunity is to build a platform that does **both**, but does each far better than the incumbents through intelligent personalisation.

2. The Three Biggest Category Gaps to Exploit

Engine Parts & Service is the highest-value gap. Marine Deals has the SKU depth, but their user experience is a generic catalogue with no vessel-specific intelligence. A customer with a Yamaha F150 has to manually search and hope they find the right part. A platform with a "My Vessel" garage that automatically filters the entire engine parts catalogue to compatible SKUs — and proactively reminds customers when their service intervals are due — would provide a dramatically superior experience in the category where customers are most anxious about getting the wrong part.

Electrical & Plumbing represents the second major opportunity. Marine Deals' 6,254 electrical SKUs and 2,010 plumbing SKUs demonstrate the enormous size of this market. But browsing 6,000 electrical products is an overwhelming experience. A platform that organises these categories around **systems** (e.g., "Build Your Battery Bank," "Design Your Freshwater System") rather than just product types would be transformative. This is where the specialist AI agents proposed in the platform design — the Electrical & Solar Sage and the Pumps & Plumbing Pro — would provide a decisive competitive advantage.

Trailer Parts is the third gap. Burnsco largely ignores this category. Marine Deals has 2,264 SKUs but no trailer-specific finder tool. Boat trailers are a high-anxiety purchase category — customers are often unsure of their trailer make, model, and specifications. A dedicated "Trailer Parts Finder" that guides customers through

identifying their trailer and finding compatible parts would be a powerful acquisition tool.

3. The Category Architecture Recommendation

Based on this analysis, the recommended top-level category architecture for the new platform should be structured to signal technical depth and intelligent personalisation, rather than simply mirroring the incumbents.

Proposed Category	Rationale
Engine & Drive	Elevates the highest-value technical category to top-level status; signals specialist credibility
Electrical & Power	Combines 12V, solar, batteries, and lighting; reflects how boaters think about their systems
Plumbing & Pumps	Dedicated top-level status for a high-volume, high-anxiety category
Fishing	Core category; must be prominent and deep
Safety & Compliance	Regulatory-driven; must be prominent and authoritative
Deck & Hardware	Anchoring, fittings, cordage, trailer
Navigation & Electronics	Chartplotters, VHF, AIS, radar
Galley & Cabin	Stoves, fridges, water systems, interior
Maintenance & Paint	Antifouling, cleaning, corrosion, service kits
Game Fishing	Dedicated section for the high-value game fishing segment; a category neither competitor serves with real depth

This architecture, combined with the “My Vessel” garage and specialist AI agents, would create a category experience that is meaningfully differentiated from both Burnsco and Marine Deals — and one that the incumbents would find extremely difficult to replicate without rebuilding their entire technology stack.